



ERP consulting and solutions are people's business, where interpersonal and intrapersonal skills are equally important—besides basic qualifications and certifications”

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also spawned the growth of IT consultant firms that specialise in helping organisations both in India and abroad in implementing ERP solutions. It also requires organisations where ERP has been adopted to develop teams for ongoing maintenance of the applications and providing support to clients,” says Jason Gonsalves, Vice President, IT and Corporate Planning, Kansai Nerolac Paints, a leading paint manufacturing company.

The implementation of ERP passes through a number of stages—analysis of the business process, the drawing up of plans for the ERP, installing and configuring the ERP package, and, finally, support and management.

Thus, the demand for ERP professionals is, naturally, in companies who have adopted or are planning to adopt ERP applications. There are several options for those who have specialised knowledge in this field—through either education or work experience. The increase in adoption of ERP by various industry verticals has led to an increase in demand for trained, skilled, and experienced ERP professionals.

The Basic Requirements

Anyone aspiring to pursue a career in ERP systems should have at least a Bachelor's degree from either functional or technical academics. The qualifications required vary according to the role to be played. The roles in this field are broadly divided into Functional and Technical, so the basic requirements are as follows.

Functional: The qualification required is a Bachelors or Masters degree, which is to be pursued depending upon the function to specialise in. Someone willing to specialise in finance must have an academic background in finance: MBA (Finance), Chartered Accountant, Cost Accounting, Financial Analyst, etc.

Freshers are not likely to be selected directly from campuses. It is advisable to pursue further formal education in the respective functional area (finance, materials management, production management, etc.) and acquiring experience of working in the domain of their interest. After gaining sound knowledge of that particular function, they can pursue training by the ERP software vendors, who have specific course modules for professionals in a specific domain.

Technical: This deals purely with the development of software. For that, a minimum of a Bachelors or Masters degree from an engineering

background, specialising in computer science or software engineering, is preferred. Students pursuing degrees in computer applications and IT are also eligible. Candidates should possess strong programming skills with a constant urge for learning, as they may have to work on multiple applications.

Courses in specific domains are offered by ERP vendors such as Oracle and SAP. Education and training can be acquired from ERP vendors' authorised centres and authorised training partners: the certifications they provide are accepted by various industry verticals. These courses are usually short-term, and a bit expensive.

The industry prefers to recruit professionals who carry a vendor-specific degree. A number of private training institutes have cropped up, and impart training on ERP products. However, “Unless authorised by the ERP product vendors, it is not a wise to opt for an unauthorised institute. There are many institutes that are not authorised and use pirated software for training,” says Nilanjan Chaudhuri, Vice President, Marketing, PSI Data Systems, a software development, solutions, and consulting service provider.

Skill Sets

Hands-on skills are looked upon as the basic benchmark for the assessment of a suitable candidate. An ERP consultant should be dynamic and able to adapt to constant change. One must possess good soft skills, too.

Functional: In a company such as one that provides consulting and solution services in ERP, consultants have to interact with clients from various industries. Understanding the client's needs, drawing up plans, and communicating these to the implementation team are typical duties. Soft skills such as being a patient and attentive listener, good communication skills, presentation skills, team-leading ability, and the ability to persuade clients are important. Good logical thinking is a must.

Technical: Those on the technical side are into programming and application development, so hard skills are valued: problem solving skills, good logical thinking and analysis, communication skills, and being a good team player.

The Importance Of Training

Every organisation has training programmes of their own for fresh recruits, irrespective of work experience and educational qualifications.

“Training programmes are important, as a shortage of trained and experienced professionals is always faced. Training helps professionals gain hands-on experience and more understanding, which will help them in the execution of their job. Though training freshly recruited staff is cost intensive, it is looked upon as a long-term investment in them,” says Chetan Pathak, Vice President, Enterprise Solutions, Ramco Systems (India) Ltd, a company that provides enterprise IT solutions and services.

“At Wipro, we have an internal Talent Transformation Cell, where we train people recruited to work with ERP systems on platforms of vendors such as Oracle, SAP, MS Dynamics, etc. After the training, they get certified on their

The Growth Path

FUNCTIONAL

Trainee Consultant
Assistant Consultant
Associate Consultant
Consultant
Senior Consultant
Lead Consultant
Managing Consultant/Project Manager
Principal Consultant
VP, Consulting and Business Solutions
Senior VP, Consulting and Business
Solutions

TECHNICAL

Trainee Software Engineer
Software Engineer
Senior Software Engineer
Associate Software Consultant
Software Consultant
Senior Software Consultant
Lead Software Consultant / Product
Manager
Technical Advisor
Senior Technical Advisor
Chief Technical Advisor / Officer

Note: The designations above are indicative